

Preface

This book began with the acid question of a friend. We had just told him that we intended to write a book that extended the model offered in “A Theory of Political Parties: Groups, Policy Demands, and Nominations” (Bawn et al. 2012). “Do you mean,” he asked, “that you’re going to do more theoretical speculation before checking to see if there’s any real evidence for what you’ve already speculated?”

The senior authors of this book took the question to heart, deciding that a better way to improve understanding of the American party system would be through close observation of parties in action, and that the large number of House nominations available for study in the upcoming election cycle, in combination with the research-friendly size of congressional districts, afforded an excellent opportunity for this observation. Thus was born the Parties on the Ground field study in the spring of 2013. Four graduate students who were at the time enrolled in a UCLA seminar on political parties agreed to join the project. With this team of six, we set out to do field interviews with participants and observers of what turned out to be fifty-five separate contests.

With two special nominations in the 2013–2014 cycle already decided and the main primary season heating up, we had no time to seek a grant to fund our research, but we managed to scrounge about \$75,000 from various sources. About half came from research funds controlled by the senior authors. Several small grants from Vanderbilt University, where Zaller was on leave in 2013–2014, provided essential additional support, including support for some voter surveys. Some personal funds were thrown in the pot. Nearly all money spent on the project went for transportation, lodging, and other travel costs. The dean of social sciences at UCLA provided some teaching relief in support of the project.

Lack of institutional funding turned out not to be a major constraint and was even on occasion a small advantage. Several Republican sources pointedly demanded to know what foundation was funding us and for what (presumably liberal) purpose. We were relieved to be able to tell them that we had no foundation support.

But another kind of potential bias is not so easily dismissed. As mentioned, an article proposing a theory of political parties was the starting point for this study. In contrast to some other leading research at the time, which viewed parties as the creatures of ambitious politicians, this article argued for the centrality of interest groups in party organization. We thus expected to find substantial interest group involvement in House primaries, and this is indeed what we did find. We strove in our field research to be open-minded about evidence for possible other dynamics, whether or not they fit our expectations. But with limited time budgets, we pushed hardest to learn about group actors who had, in our view, been previously neglected.

In light of this background, our claims about groups and parties should not be viewed as findings that emerged from wholly disinterested field observation. Yet this book is by no means a simple affirmation of initial expectations. For one thing, these expectations were so general as to offer very little insight into House nominations. And even if our expectations had provided much more guidance than they did, no one could conduct 346 interviews with diverse actors in 55 contests in every part of the United States without encountering multiple surprises and confusions. We would thus echo what Daniel Boone said when asked if he had ever been lost: "No, but I was once bewildered for three days." We never lost our sense that groups were important in party nominations, but we were sometimes bewildered as to what that importance entailed in practice. But by immersing ourselves in the messy reality of nomination contests, we observed significant behavioral regularities that existing scholarship had missed or assumed away. At least as important, we gained a sense of how theoretical concepts manifested on the ground. These regularities and understandings, rather than the simple fact of group involvement, are where this study's contribution lies.

Over the twelve-year period of this study, we were fortunate to have many students, colleagues, and friends who offered their assistance and critical assessments. Foremost among these are several cohorts of UCLA undergraduates who, in our annual seminars on House nominations, critiqued early versions of this book, dug out useful information for our case

studies, challenged us to hurry up and finish it, and in some cases worked as research assistants on the project. We particularly thank Mellissa Meisels, Nico Studens, Lexi Daetz, Darla Lavi, Jared Tay, Courteney Craney, Angela Yip, Joseph Mauro, Kian Zabhini, Christopher Leach, David Bezoian, Charles David McGrath, Varant Anmahouni, Natalie Cooke, Jack Hand, Caroline Leahy, Christine Kabayan, Harman Basra, Kat Bocanegra, and Karin Thrasher.

We also thank colleagues who invited us to present our early work at seminars and conferences at universities that include USC, UCSD, Princeton, Rice, Georgetown, Vanderbilt, Yale, the University of Maryland, the Massachusetts Institute of Technology, the Stanford Business School, the University of Chicago, the University of Michigan, the Weatherhead Center for International Affairs' PIEP conference at Harvard, the Travers Conference on Ethics and Accountability at UC Berkeley, and the Department of Political Science at UC Berkeley. Our project evolved dramatically in response to the feedback we received at these venues, and we are very grateful for it.

An Author-Meets-Critics event at the 2024 annual meeting of the American Political Science Association, where the critics were Sara Anzia, Nolan McCarty, and Eric Schickler, led to further important change. A book conference in January 2025 at the Center for the Study of Democratic Institutions at Vanderbilt University, just when we thought we were finishing the book, led to a major and much-needed reorganization. As mentioned above, the Vanderbilt center also contributed early financial help to the project.

Earlier versions of some of our results were reported in Bawn et al. 2019 and Bawn et al. 2023 and are used here with permission.

We received thoughtful and helpful comments—in some cases multiple rounds thereof—from many people, including Barbara Geddes, Jeff Frieden, Sandy Gordon, John Sides, Hans Hassell, Gary Jacobson, Mark Westlye, Debra Zaller, Marty Cohen, David Karol, Hans Noel, Seth Masket, and Bruce Oppenheimer. We are also grateful for the excellent work of our copy editor at the University of Chicago Press, Jessica Wilson.

We especially thank Larry Bartels. He was a friendly but critical advisor from the instigation of the project to its final review at the Vanderbilt symposium. The value of his support is difficult to overstate.

All this said, any study of the local politics of fifty-five party nominations is bound to get some of its facts and findings wrong. We were sensitive to this danger and strove to mitigate it, but we warn readers of

the problem. And, in the end, we of course take full responsibility for all errors of fact and analysis that escaped our efforts and made it into the book.

Our greatest debt is to our sources: the many people who took time to share with us their experiences doing the on-the-ground work of party politics. Not a few waived hefty consultation fees they would normally charge, many more took hits to extremely busy schedules to help with our study, and all had to deal with the uncertainties of sharing sensitive information with an unknown UCLA interviewer. A Tea Party leader whom we met at a GOP fundraiser illustrates the last point. We struck up a friendly conversation with her between candidate speeches and agreed to do a formal interview the next day. But as the leader was searching her purse for her calendar, she suddenly asked, “But won’t this study help the Democrats?” We assured her that the study aimed at helping all Americans to better understand House nominations, but she remained worried. She set an interview time for the next day but warned that if she woke up with doubts in the middle of the night, she might need to cancel. Sure enough, the following email arrived early the next morning: “I must cancel our appt at noon today. Sorry I have decided not to participate. Good Luck.”

Happily for us, enough people overcame tight time budgets and understandable uncertainties to make our study possible. As best we could tell, civic-mindedness—the wish to contribute to public understanding of the country’s politics—was the most common motive for doing so. To these good and helpful citizens, we dedicate this book.